point that if she was a Buddhist in her later years without there being any allusion to her *conversion* to that religion, then she is likely to have been a Buddhist when she first met Ashoka. Her children—the son Mahinda, and daughter Sanghamitra—are described as having chosen to 'receive the Pabbaja ordination', i.e. a ceremony for what can be translated as 'leaving the world'. This was the initial step before ordination into the monastic order.[31]

That said, the fact that Ashoka had loved and lived with a woman who is remembered by history as a Buddhist does not seem immediately to have influenced the trajectory of his life. On the contrary, his long sojourn at Ujjayini would come to an end in circumstances which would, almost certainly, have been disapproved of by devout Buddhists.

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Some ten years after Ashoka became viceroy in Ujjayini his emperor-father fell critically ill in Pataliputra. Grave ill health in a monarch usually has serious political ramifications, and in this case the king was quite old. The prevailing sense will have been that he would be dead before long. It is thus not fortuitous that his father's failing health became the reason for Ashoka ending his residence in Malwa and returning to Pataliputra, where his bloody assumption of the Mauryan throne would happen. As before, we must depend on later traditions in which this turn of events figures amidst a fascinating if somewhat unverifiable maze of memories and stories.

There are various versions of how these events came to pass. The *Mahavamsa* records the accession of Ashoka with characteristic brevity, merely mentioning that upon Bindusara's illness he came back to Pataliputra: here 'he made himself master of the city, after his father's death, he caused his eldest brother to be slain and took on himself the sovereignty in the splendid city.'[32] There are other ways in which this right royal fratricide is remembered in the Sri Lankan texts, where Ashoka is